

Reading tiny cohorts

Week 5, Lecture 2 · LangoBee to \$10K MRR

Summer 2026 · Operating a Solo Language App from Zero Revenue

What we'll cover

- What $n=12$ can and cannot tell you about your product
- The D1 bar: 30% as a directional threshold
- How to classify your early signals as passing, failing, or inconclusive
- Mom Test rules and the bad data patterns that fool founders
- The two-unprompted-praise bar for qualifying qualitative signal
- Segmenting stickiness by content type: shorts vs long-form in LangoBee

What $n=12$ can and cannot tell you

The D1 bar: 30% return

Week 4 introduced this threshold: if fewer than 30% of activated users return on day 1, the activation event is not delivering on its promise.

Two things happen at low D1:

- **Flattening:** users return occasionally but irregularly. You have some value but no habit.
- **Decaying:** users never return after day 1. The product delivered nothing worth coming back for.

At $n=12$, you cannot distinguish flattening from early decay with confidence. But if D1 is below 15%, that is not noise. You have a signal worth acting on regardless of sample size.

LangoBee May cohort: 24% overall return rate. Borderline. Worth segmenting before drawing conclusions.

(Primary data, June 2026)

What passes, fails, or is inconclusive at n=12

At twelve users, the statistical power is low. Use directional categories, not significance tests.

Passes (act on it):

- Two or more users return unprompted, on consecutive days, without being nudged
- One user's session time doubles week over week

Fails (act on it immediately):

- Zero D1 returns across all twelve users
- Every user who returns was personally messaged first

Inconclusive (needs more data):

- D1 between 20-40% with mixed engagement patterns
- One power user who is a personal contact of the founder

The rule: if you would be embarrassed to show the number to an investor, it is a fail signal regardless of n

The false signal trap at small n

Three patterns that produce false positives with tiny cohorts:

- **The founder effect.** Users who know you personally return out of social obligation. They are not your ICP.
- **The launch burst.** The first week has high engagement because the product is new. Week 3 is the real test.
- **The vocal minority.** One enthusiastic user in a Slack thread sounds like traction. Check whether they are returning in the data, not just talking.

At $n=12$, the safe posture is: treat every positive signal as a hypothesis to test, not a conclusion to celebrate.

Qual and quant pairing

The Mom Test: three rules

Rob Fitzpatrick's Mom Test gives three rules for conversations that produce real data rather than polite noise:

1. **Talk about their life, not your idea.** Ask what they actually do today, not what they would do if your product existed.
2. **Ask about the past, not the hypothetical future.** "What did you do last time you encountered this?" produces facts. "Would you use this?" produces wishes.
3. **Listen more than you talk.** If you are pitching, you are not learning.

These rules exist because users will tell you what you want to hear if you give them the chance. The Mom Test removes that chance.

(Fitzpatrick, 2013)

Bad data patterns: what founders mistake for signal

Four patterns that produce junk data in early conversations:

- **Compliments.** "This is really cool" is not a buying signal. It is politeness.
- **Hypothetical fluff.** "I would definitely use this every day" has never predicted retention accurately.
- **Wishlists.** Feature requests from people who have not completed a single session are not product direction. They are distraction.
- **The leading question.** "Don't you think it would be better if...?" guarantees agreement and teaches you nothing.

The tell: if a user is smiling and agreeing and you feel good afterward, check whether they gave you a single concrete fact about their behavior.

(Fitzpatrick, 2013)

The real quote

You shouldn't ask your mom whether your business is a good idea, because she loves you and will lie to you -- and the same rule applies to every customer conversation. (Paraphrased)

Rob Fitzpatrick (2013)

"The Mom Test," momtestbook.com

The two-unprompted-praise bar

Qualitative signal is unreliable until it is unprompted and repeated.

The bar: two or more users, independently, volunteer the same specific praise without being asked.

What counts:

- A user sends you a message at 9am saying "I watched three videos this morning"
- Two different users mention the same specific feature in unsolicited follow-up

What does not count:

- A user agrees enthusiastically when you ask "do you like the shorts?"
- A user gives positive feedback in a scheduled feedback session

The two-unprompted bar is strict because prompted praise is nearly always inflated. If you are hearing it unprompted from multiple people, you have found something real.

(Miqicovsky, 2019)

Segmenting by content type

LangoBee's two stickiest users

The primary data tells a clear story about who is actually returning (June 2026):

- **User A:** returns specifically for shorts. 7 active days in the observation window. No other content type in session data.
- **User B:** returns for long-form video. Multiple extended sessions. Does not engage with shorts at all.

Both are outliers compared to the median activated user (1 active day, about 2 minutes total).

The insight: the product is not uniformly weak. Two distinct content surfaces each have one real advocate. The question is whether those are two different products or two entry points to the same product.

(Primary data, June 2026)

How to segment by content type in PostHog

The goal: separate your retention curves by the first content type a user engaged with.

Steps:

1. Create a user property at activation: `first_content_type` set to `"shorts"` or `"long_form"` on the first `word_lookup_opened` event
2. In the retention chart, group by `first_content_type`
3. Compare D1, D7, and D14 return rates between segments

What to look for:

- If shorts D1 is 40% and long-form D1 is 15%, you have two different activation events disguised as one product
- If both are below 20%, content type is not the lever: onboarding is

This takes about 20 minutes to wire. Do it before the next cohort arrives.

What the segmentation tells you next

If shorts users retain better, the next moves are:

- Make the shorts feed the default first surface for new signups
- Run concierge sessions that start in shorts, not the reader
- Check whether `word_lookup_opened` rate is higher in shorts sessions (it is: 5,225 events / 30d suggests the format is driving lookup behavior)

If long-form users retain better:

- The reader is the core product. Shorts may be top-of-funnel.
- Onboarding should walk users to a long-form text that matches their level immediately

Either answer is useful. Running the cohorts without the segmentation means neither answer surfaces.

(Primary data, June 2026)

Take-aways

1. At $n=12$, use directional categories (passes / fails / inconclusive) rather than statistical significance. A zero-D1 cohort is a fail signal at any sample size.
2. The Mom Test rules exist to prevent polite noise from masquerading as signal. Ask about behavior in the past, not intentions in the future.
3. Compliments, hypothetical fluff, and feature wishlists are bad data. The two-unprompted-praise bar filters most of it out.
4. LangoBee has two stickiest users on two different surfaces. That is a segmentation hypothesis, not a conclusion. Wire the PostHog split before the next cohort.
5. Qual and quant must pair: the interview tells you why, the retention curve tells you whether. Neither is sufficient alone.

What's next

- **Reading:** Week 5 at </c/langobee-10k-mrr-26su/readings/wk05>
- **Section this week:** Run one Mom Test conversation with a lapsed user (D7+ without return). Post three concrete facts you learned.
- **HW5 (due end of week):** D1 segmented by content type from PostHog, plus notes from your concierge session and Mom Test conversation
- **Week 6 preview:** Activation engineering: defining your activation event precisely, instrumenting it, and iterating on the first-session flow